Ki Tetzei – A Checklist for Elul

This week's parsha, **Ki Tetzei**, is truly an amazing parsha. On a personal note, it was my **Bar Mitzvah parsha,** 29 years ago, which already makes it meaningful to me. But beyond that, Ki Tetzei is remarkable because it falls at a very opportune time: we are in **Elul**, the month of *cheshbon ha-nefesh*, of taking stock of who I am, where I stand, where my growth has taken me, and where my alignment with Hashem's will should be going forward.

Ki Tetzei is also unique in another way: it is the **sixth parsha in Sefer Devarim**, which has eleven parshiyot total. That means it stands at the **center point** of the book. This is a perfect moment to pause, reflect on what has come before, and realign ourselves before moving forward.

A Quick Recap of the Journey in Devarim

- In **Devarim**, Moshe began by reviewing the mistakes of the past and warning us not to repeat them.
- In **Va'etchanan**, we were called to align ourselves with **Hashem's ratzon**, highlighted through the Ten Commandments, from the lowest level of resisting jealousy all the way up to "*Anochi Hashem Elokecha*."
- In **Eikev**, we were reminded not to step on the "small mitzvot" (*mitzvot kalot*), since we don't know which mitzvot are greater in Hashem's eyes (Rashi to Devarim 7:12).
- In **Re'eh**, we were shown how to move beyond selfishness, avoid idolatry, and embrace tzedakah and generosity.
- In **Shoftim**, we came down to the practical: establishing justice, structure, and boundaries in society.

Now comes **Ki Tetzei**, the midpoint. With its **74 mitzvot** — more than any other parsha — it provides a practical checklist for daily living.

Derech Eretz as the Foundation

Pirkei Avot 3:17 teaches: *"Rabbi Eliezer the son of Azariah said: If there is no Torah, there is no derech eretz; if there is no derech eretz, there is no Torah."* Pirkei Avot (3:10) also teaches: *"One who is pleasing to his fellow men, is pleasing to G-d. But one who is not pleasing to his fellow men, is not pleasing to G-d."* Our parsha is filled with mitzvot that emphasize **how we live with one another**, not just our private service of Hashem.

The parsha opens with the laws of the **captive woman** (*eshet yefat to'ar*). The Torah recognizes that in the heat of war, human passions are inflamed. Instead of pretending this doesn't exist, the Torah regulates it. The requirement to bring her home, remove the external

beauty, and wait a full month (Devarim 21:12–13, Rashi ad loc.) is not a punishment to her — it is a reset for him. It forces the soldier to step back from adrenaline and passion into calm reflection: “Am I truly choosing this relationship in reality, or was it only in the heat of the moment?” This law speaks not only to desire but to responsibility: *Am I building my home on a foundation of holiness or selfishness?*

Immediately afterward comes the law of the **hated wife** and then the **rebellious son** (*ben sorer u’moreh*). Chazal (Sanhedrin 107a) point out the progression: if one’s household is built without proper love and alignment, it spirals into hatred and eventually destructive children. The Torah is not just giving laws; it is teaching us to pause and ask: *What kind of home am I building?*

From the Home to Society

The second aliyah emphasizes dignity even in judgment: even one executed by the court must be buried respectfully (Devarim 21:23). Then come **hashavat aveidah** (returning lost property) and **prikah u’te’ina** (helping lift a fallen animal) — mitzvot that force us to look outward and help others, even those we may not like (Rambam, Hilchot Gezeilah Va’Aveidah 11:3).

We are even commanded to show compassion to animals with **shiluach haken** — sending away the mother bird before taking her chicks (Devarim 22:6–7). The Ramban explains this is not about the bird’s feelings, but about cultivating compassion within us, training us to act with mercy in every area of life.

Then comes the mitzvah to build a **ma’akeh** (fence) around a roof (Devarim 22:8). Chazal see this as more than architecture: it’s about creating **healthy boundaries** in life. It’s not a wall to keep people out; it’s a guardrail to protect those already inside our homes. The Gemara (Bava Kama 15b) expands this principle to every dangerous situation: we must take responsibility to remove hazards and protect others.

The Broader Checklist

As the parsha continues, we encounter mitzvot that cover almost every aspect of human life:

- **Kilayim and sha’atnez** — avoiding improper mixtures (Devarim 22:9–11).
- **Tzitzit** — constant reminders of Hashem’s mitzvot (22:12, Menachot 43b).
- **Giluy arayot** — prohibited relationships, setting boundaries in holiness.
- **Moving boundary markers** — respecting property and not imposing on others (Devarim 19:14, reaffirmed here).
- **Justice in business** — honest weights and measures (25:13–16, Rambam Hilchot Geneivah 7:1).
- **Kindness to workers, converts, orphans, and widows** (24:14–22).

Altogether, Ki Tetzei is like a **spiritual mirror**: Am I treating others with dignity? Am I acting responsibly at home and in business? Am I setting boundaries that protect life and holiness? Am I remembering the vulnerable, those who are easily forgotten, and lifting them up or am I finding the shortcuts in life to capture to small pennies from others? After all, isn't it only wrong if I get caught and in trougle afterwards?

Preparing for Rosh Hashanah

All of this is given **now, in Elul**. Just as *Ani L'dodi V'dodi Li* (Shir HaShirim 6:3) reminds us that Hashem is close and I should be putting the wants and will of my beloved before me and my beloved with also keep my wants and will in front of her, Ki Tetzei provides the **practical checklist** for the cheshbon hanefesh of this month and helps me prepare for a sweeter coming year.

We are only a few weeks away from Rosh Hashanah, the day when we proclaim: *"Hayom harat olam, hayom ya'amid bamishpat kol yetzurei olam"* — today is the birthday of the world, today all creatures stand in judgment.

So the question Ki Tetzei pushes us to ask is: **Am I living with derech eretz? Am I honoring my family, helping my fellow, caring for the vulnerable, and creating healthy boundaries in my life?**

Because when we do, we are not just preparing for Rosh Hashanah — we are preparing to stand before Hashem with lives that reflect His image.